

Dear Jen,

This is twice now that I have gotten to talk to you! That is more than the vast majority of anyone here has talked to their families yet it doesn't feel like I get the opportunity enough. Well, you sound like you are doing well even if you are lonely. I hope you enjoyed your visit east—and most of all I can't believe that you haven't received any mail! Well, once again it was great to just talk to you.

Did you know that the only phones available for us are at the Corps level? That sucks, and the phones are not even dedicated for personal use. Instead, if we want to call home, we basically have to fake an emergency and use one of the few satellite phones we have available. The whole excursion got me out of my TOC for a little while—which was really nice.

It was about a 20 minute drive from our location to the Corps TOC at Baghdad International Airport. The term “international” is quite a joke really. The airport is small and shows serious signs of battle damage. Two bombed planes lay strewn across one of the airport's two runways. Both used to belong to Iraqi Airways, and I wonder if they may not have been the Airlines only two planes. The first, a fairly large passenger jet, sat flat against the ground. Its nose cone was still in tact along with the cockpit. The main hull of the jet, however, was completely torn to shreds. The top canopy had been ripped open and the passenger compartment was nothing but charred ash. The tail fin, much like the cockpit, still stood tall at the far end. The whole plane looked like it had been opened with a can-opener and then been firebombed. The second plane was a small propeller plane. It not longer had any landing gear and had received a few artillery shells of its own.

The rest of the airport was equally unimpressive. Baghdad International Airport consists of one Air Traffic Control Tower, and one terminal. Both are small compared to average U.S. Airports. There are also two warehouses and one Airplane hangar at the site. The hangar is in perfect condition and now houses ten to twelve, US Kiowa Warrior Helicopters. The concrete tarmac is now home to twenty Apache Fighter Helicopters, and the hangars are home to the Air Force Command. All of the airports former support vehicles (the trucks with ramps for boarding airplanes, the little tow vehicles etc.) lie uselessly off to the side—most of which are damaged beyond repair. I can imagine it will be some time before commercial flights fly in here again.

On the way over, I also saw one of Saddam Hussein's proud palaces, now the headquarters for the Special Forces, Green Berets. The palace is a gorgeous, middle-eastern style building, set on top of a hill that rises dominantly above the surrounding terrain. The palace is surrounded by lush green valley on all sides and it is obvious that the estate used to be heavily guarded. The entire complex is surrounded by a wall that is no shorter than 10 feet up, and the “castle” comes complete with a mote. Guard towers